served as president of the DTSB, the East German sports ministry. During his tenure, the Stasi took control of drugs in sports, and – swollen with each international ‘triumph’ – doping became official policy in 1975. It seems that in the politics of sport, Honecker was the hammer, not the anvil, and approved a systematic approach to doping – through the ‘state plan 14.25’ making it policy to administer muscle-building anabolic steroids to young athletes. In terms of producing medal winners, the project was a complete success. In a dark-of-night operation, neither athletes nor their parents were advised of the practice.

Throughout the Montreal Games, a clandestine medical facility outside the Olympic Village was set up where athletes were given performance-enhancing steroids ranging from testosterone to epitestosterone – administered at scientifically determined intervals to avoid drug tests. At the close of the Games, after undermining the integrity of one of the world’s most prestigious sporting events, Stasi agents dumped ten suitcases of drugs and hypodermic syringes into Montreal’s St Lawrence River.

Back in Germany, the glorious Olympic team was trotted about before the local press like prize cattle. Honecker paid tribute to the medal winners and expressed to the sportsmen, coaches and officials ‘thanks and recognition for their exemplary actions, high fighting morale and outstanding sports performances with which they represented their socialist fatherland so well’.3 Asked what he thought was the reason for the fact that East German athletes, although the GDR population was only one-tenth of that of the United States, won more medals than the latter’s athletes, Honecker replied:

The reasons for the successes of our athletes are manifold. Essentially, they are derived from the fact that in our country numerous talents are being promoted with the help of children’s and youth associations. I believe that this is the main reason for our athletes’ success.

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